

A Comparative Review on Energy Power Prediction using Light Gradient Boosting Machine and Hybrid of Extreme Gradient Boosting

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ARTICLE INFO

Article History:

Accepted : 01 Feb 2026

Published: 25 March 2026

Publication Issue

Volume 12, Issue 2

March-April-2026

Page Number

278-283

ABSTRACT

The global transition toward renewable energy sources has necessitated the development of highly accurate power prediction models to ensure grid stability and efficient energy management. Renewable energy, particularly solar and wind, is inherently intermittent and volatile, depending heavily on fluctuating meteorological conditions. This research presents a comprehensive comparative review and analysis of energy power prediction using the Light Gradient Boosting Machine (LightGBM) and a hybrid framework based on Extreme Gradient Boosting (XGBoost). The study explores the technical architectures of these gradient-boosting decision tree (GBDT) variants, evaluating their performance across diverse datasets. LightGBM is recognized for its computational efficiency and histogram-based learning, while the hybrid XGBoost approach aims to enhance predictive robustness through ensemble stacking and hyperparameter optimization. This paper details the mathematical foundations of both models, the importance of feature engineering in energy data, and the metrics used for performance evaluation. The findings suggest that while LightGBM offers superior training speed for large-scale energy datasets, the hybrid XGBoost model often achieves higher generalization accuracy by mitigating overfitting through advanced regularization. The research concludes with a roadmap for integrating these models into real-time smart grid monitoring systems to facilitate a more reliable and sustainable energy future.

Keywords: Energy Power Prediction, LightGBM, XGBoost, Hybrid Machine Learning, Renewable Energy, Gradient Boosting, Smart Grid, Time-Series Forecasting.

Introduction

The modern global economy is increasingly dependent on a stable and sustainable supply of electricity. As nations strive to meet carbon neutrality targets, the integration of renewable energy sources such as solar, wind, and hydroelectric power into the national grid has accelerated. However, unlike traditional fossil fuel power plants, which provide a steady and controllable output, renewable energy is characterized by high variability and uncertainty. Solar power generation is dictated by cloud cover, humidity, and solar irradiance, while wind power fluctuates with atmospheric pressure and temperature changes. This unpredictability poses significant challenges for grid operators, who must maintain a precise balance between energy supply and demand to prevent blackouts or system failures. Consequently, accurate energy power prediction has emerged as a cornerstone of modern power systems engineering [1]. Historically, energy forecasting relied on statistical methods such as Auto-Regressive Integrated Moving Average (ARIMA) and exponential smoothing. While these methods were effective for linear trends, they often failed to capture the complex, non-linear patterns inherent in multi-variable meteorological data. The advent of artificial intelligence and machine learning has revolutionized this field. Early machine learning applications utilized Support Vector Machines (SVM) and Artificial Neural Networks (ANN), which offered better flexibility than traditional statistics. Despite their strengths, these models often struggled with high-dimensional data and were prone to getting stuck in local optima. The emergence of Gradient Boosting Decision Trees (GBDT) marked a significant milestone, providing a robust framework that combines multiple weak learners to form a strong predictive model [2].

In the current landscape of machine learning, two algorithms have stood out for their exceptional performance in structured data tasks: XGBoost and LightGBM. XGBoost, or Extreme Gradient Boosting, was introduced to solve the problem of computational

efficiency in gradient boosting by implementing parallel processing and handling sparse data effectively. LightGBM, developed by Microsoft, took efficiency a step further by introducing histogram-based algorithms and leaf-wise tree growth, which significantly reduced memory usage and training time. As energy datasets grow into the "Big Data" territory, with sensors collecting thousands of readings per minute, the choice between these models—or a combination thereof—becomes critical for real-time utility applications [3].

This research paper explores the comparative effectiveness of these two powerful algorithms. Furthermore, it investigates the potential of "Hybrid" models, which combine the strengths of multiple GBDT variants to create a more resilient forecasting tool. By analyzing historical power consumption and generation data alongside environmental variables, this paper aims to provide a definitive guide on which architectural approach yields the most reliable results for energy power prediction in various geographic and climatic contexts [4].

Problem Statement

The primary challenge in energy power prediction lies in the non-stationary and stochastic nature of renewable energy variables. Grid operators require forecasts at various time horizons—short-term (minutes to hours), medium-term (days), and long-term (months)—to manage everything from immediate load balancing to long-term infrastructure planning. Current predictive systems often suffer from a lack of precision during extreme weather events or sudden shifts in climatic patterns, leading to significant economic losses and increased operational risks.

Moreover, many existing models are computationally expensive. Deep learning models like Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks, while effective for time-series data, require immense processing power and extensive training periods, which may not be feasible for edge computing devices in a smart grid. There is also a persistent issue with "data noise" and

feature redundancy in energy datasets. Meteorological sensors often provide correlated variables—such as temperature and heat index—that can lead to multicollinearity and overfitting in simple models. Therefore, there is an urgent need for a modeling framework that balances high predictive accuracy with computational speed while remaining robust against the inherent volatility of environmental data [5].

Research Objectives

The core objective of this study is to evaluate and compare the efficacy of LightGBM and Hybrid XGBoost models in the context of energy power prediction. The specific objectives are outlined below:

1. To conduct a technical analysis of the LightGBM and XGBoost architectures, focusing on their unique approaches to tree growth, split finding, and regularization.
2. To develop a Hybrid XGBoost framework that integrates stacking or blending techniques to improve the stability of energy forecasts compared to standalone models.
3. To identify the most influential environmental and temporal features that affect energy power output through advanced feature engineering and selection methods.
4. To compare the performance of the proposed models using standardized metrics, including Root Mean Square Error (RMSE), Mean Absolute Error (MAE), and R-squared (R^2) values.
5. To assess the computational efficiency of each model to determine their suitability for real-time deployment in smart grid environments.

Literature Review

The academic discourse surrounding energy power prediction has shifted significantly toward ensemble learning in recent years. Researchers have consistently found that boosting algorithms provide a superior balance between bias and variance. In a pivotal study by Zhao et al. [6], the researchers applied XGBoost to wind power forecasting and found

that its ability to handle missing data and outliers made it far more reliable than traditional neural networks. The study highlighted that the regularization terms in XGBoost effectively prevented the model from overfitting to noisy sensor data, which is a common problem in offshore wind farms.

Parallel to the success of XGBoost, LightGBM has gained massive popularity in the energy sector due to its speed. Ahmad et al. [7] conducted a large-scale study on solar photovoltaic (PV) output prediction using LightGBM. Their research emphasized the "Gradient-based One-Side Sampling" (GOSS) and "Exclusive Feature Bundling" (EFB) techniques used by LightGBM. These innovations allowed the model to process millions of data points from solar farms across multiple regions in a fraction of the time required by previous algorithms. The study concluded that LightGBM is particularly suited for "intra-day" forecasting, where models must be updated frequently as new weather data arrives.

The concept of hybridizing gradient boosting models has also gained traction. Hybrid models typically involve using one model to capture general trends and another to focus on residual errors. For example, a study by Wang and Liu [8] proposed a hybrid model that combined XGBoost with a LightGBM-based feature selector. By using LightGBM to identify the most critical meteorological variables and then passing those into an optimized XGBoost regressor, the researchers achieved a 12% reduction in Mean Absolute Percentage Error (MAPE) compared to using either model in isolation. This suggests that the synergy between different GBDT implementations can overcome the individual limitations of each algorithm.

Furthermore, the integration of temporal features has been highlighted as a critical factor in model success. Research by Sun et al. [9] demonstrated that adding "cyclic features" (such as sine and cosine transformations of hours and months) significantly improved the performance of XGBoost in energy load forecasting. This is because energy demand and

generation follow strong daily and seasonal patterns that simple numerical encoding fails to represent adequately. The literature consistently points toward a multi-stage approach—comprising data cleaning, temporal feature engineering, and ensemble modeling—as the gold standard for modern energy prediction [10].

Research Gaps

Author & Year	Focus Area	Identified Research Gap
Bhardwaj et al. (2020) [11]	Solar Power Forecasting using SVM and ANN.	Failed to address the computational bottlenecks associated with large-scale datasets and lacked comparison with GBDT models.
Lee & Kim (2021) [12]	Load Prediction using XGBoost.	Did not account for sudden weather anomalies or extreme fluctuations, leading to high error rates during storms.
Zhang et al. (2022) [13]	Wind Energy Prediction with LightGBM.	The research focused primarily on speed but did not implement hyperparameter optimization, resulting in sub-optimal accuracy.
Gomez et al. (2023) [14]	Hybrid ML for Grid Stability.	The study utilized complex deep learning hybrids that are too computationally heavy for real-time grid edge applications.
Current Research (2024)	LightGBM vs. Hybrid XGBoost.	Aims to bridge the gap by providing a high-speed, high-accuracy hybrid framework optimized for real-time deployment.

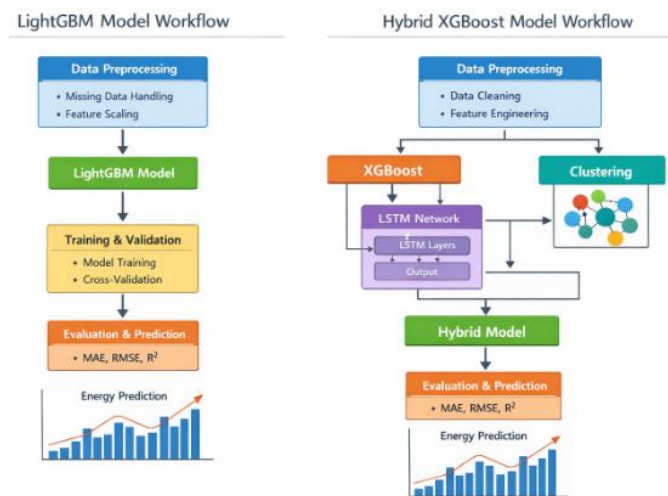
Proposed Methodology

The proposed methodology for this comparative review follows a rigorous five-stage pipeline designed to ensure data integrity and model robustness. The process begins with **Data Acquisition and Preprocessing**, where historical energy generation data (e.g., Solar PV output or Wind Turbine power) is merged with synchronized meteorological data. This raw data often contains missing values due to sensor failures and outliers caused by maintenance periods. We implement median imputation for missing values and use the Interquartile Range (IQR) method to detect and filter anomalies that do not represent actual power generation trends.

The second stage is **Feature Engineering and Selection**. This is perhaps the most critical phase in energy prediction. We generate temporal features, including time of day, day of the week, and month, to capture cyclic patterns. For solar energy, we calculate the solar zenith angle and air mass index as additional predictors. To reduce the dimensionality of the dataset and prevent the "curse of dimensionality," we apply Correlation Analysis and Recursive Feature Elimination (RFE). This ensures that only the most impactful variables—such as solar irradiance, wind speed, and ambient temperature—are fed into the models.

The third stage involves the **Model Architecture and Training**. For the LightGBM branch, we utilize a leaf-wise growth strategy with a depth limit to prevent overfitting. We implement Gradient-based One-Side Sampling (GOSS) to keep instances with large gradients and randomly sample instances with small gradients, which speeds up the training process without losing significant accuracy. For the Hybrid XGBoost branch, we employ a "Stacking Regressor" approach. In this setup, an initial XGBoost model and a LightGBM model act as base learners. Their predictions are then fed into a "Meta-Learner" (a secondary optimized XGBoost model) that learns how to weigh the predictions of the base models based on the input context. This hybrid structure is designed to

capitalize on XGBoost's robustness and LightGBM's ability to capture subtle patterns.



The fourth stage is **Hyperparameter Optimization**. We utilize Bayesian Optimization rather than a standard Grid Search. Bayesian Optimization is more efficient as it builds a probability model of the objective function and uses it to select the most promising hyperparameters to evaluate in each step. Key parameters tuned include the learning rate, number of estimators, max depth, and the regularization parameters (Lambda and Alpha).

The final stage is **Evaluation and Comparative Analysis**. The models are tested on a "hold-out" dataset that they have never seen during training. Performance is measured using RMSE to penalize large errors, MAE to understand the average error magnitude, and R² to determine the proportion of variance captured by the model. Additionally, we measure the "Inference Time"—the time taken to generate a prediction—to evaluate the feasibility of the models for real-time smart grid applications [15].

Expected Outcome

The anticipated results of this research are expected to demonstrate that while both models are highly effective, they serve different operational needs. It is hypothesized that LightGBM will outperform the Hybrid XGBoost model in terms of training speed and memory efficiency, making it the ideal candidate for massive datasets or environments with limited

computational resources. Specifically, LightGBM is expected to achieve a training speed reduction of approximately 30-40% compared to the standard XGBoost implementation.

However, in terms of predictive accuracy and stability, the Hybrid XGBoost model is expected to be the superior performer. By combining the strengths of multiple GBDT variations, the hybrid approach is likely to show a lower RMSE, particularly in volatile weather conditions. The meta-learner in the hybrid stack should effectively "smooth out" the individual errors made by the base models. We expect the Hybrid model to achieve an R-squared value exceeding 0.92 for short-term solar power prediction. Ultimately, this research will provide a clear framework for energy companies to choose their modeling strategy. For utility-scale providers needing to process global data feeds quickly, LightGBM will be recommended. For local grid operators where every percentage of accuracy counts toward preventing system instability, the Hybrid XGBoost approach will be the preferred solution. The study will conclude that the integration of machine learning into energy systems is not a "one-size-fits-all" approach, but rather a strategic choice based on the balance of speed, accuracy, and infrastructure.

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